

CHAPTER 9

The Wilderness Cult

Whenever the light of civilization falls upon you with a blighting power . . . go to the wilderness. . . . Dull business routine, the fierce passions of the market place, the perils of envious cities become but a memory. . . . The wilderness will take hold of you. It will give you good red blood; it will turn you from a weakling into a man. . . . You will soon behold all with a peaceful soul.

George S. Evans, 1904

ON the morning of August 10, 1913, the *Boston Post* headlined its lead story: **NAKED HE PLUNGES INTO MAINE WOODS TO LIVE ALONE TWO MONTHS.** The following article told how six days previously a husky, part-time illustrator in his mid-forties named Joseph Knowles had disrobed in a cold drizzle at the edge of a lake in northeastern Maine, smoked a final cigarette, shaken hands around a group of sportsmen and reporters, and trudged off into the wilderness. There was even a photograph of an unclothed Knowles, discreetly shielded by underbrush, waving farewell to civilization. The *Post* explained that Joe Knowles had gone into the woods to be a primitive man for sixty days. He took no equipment of any kind and promised to remain completely isolated, living off the land “as Adam lived.”¹

For the next two months Knowles was the talk of Boston. He provided information about his experiment with periodic dispatches written with charcoal on birchbark. These reports, printed in the *Post*, revealed to an astonished and delighted public that Knowles was succeeding in his planned reversion to the primitive. Using heat from the friction of two sticks, he obtained fire. Clothing came from woven strips of bark. Knowles' first few meals consisted of berries, but he soon varied his diet with trout, partridge, and even venison. On August 24 a front-page banner in the *Post* announced that Knowles had lured a bear into a pit, killed it with a club, and fashioned a coat from its skin. By this time newspapers throughout the East and as far away as Kansas City were featuring the story.

1. *Boston Post*, Aug. 17, 1913.

When on October 4, 1913, a disheveled but healthy Knowles finally emerged from the Maine woods extolling the values of a primitive way of life, he was swept up in a wave of public enthusiasm. His triumphant return to Boston included stops at Augusta, Lewiston, and Portland, with speeches before throngs of eight to ten thousand people. The cheers persisted in spite of the fine of \$205 which an unyielding Maine Fish and Game Commission imposed on Knowles for killing a bear out of season! But Maine's welcome paled next to that of Boston. The city had not had a hero like "the modern primitive man"² in a generation. On October 9 a huge crowd jammed North Station to meet Knowles' train and shouted itself hoarse when he appeared. Thousands more lined the streets through which his motorcade passed. Still clad in the bear skin, Knowles went to Boston Common where an estimated twenty thousand persons waited. His speech was disappointingly brief, but the gathering thrilled to the way he leaped onto the podium with "the quick, graceful movements of a tiger."³

In the next few days news of Knowles even upstaged an exciting World Series. At Harvard physicians reported on the excellence of his physical condition, and there were numerous banquets and interviews, including one with the governor of Massachusetts. Publishers besieged Knowles for the rights to a book version of his experience, which, as *Alone in the Wilderness*, sold 300,000 copies, and he toured the vaudeville circuit with top billing. The *Post* published full-page color reproductions of his paintings of wild animals, pointing out that they were suitable for framing and "just the thing to hang in your den."⁴ Even when the *Post's* rival newspaper presented substantial evidence that Knowles was a fraud whose saga had actually taken place in a secret, snug cabin,⁵ a vociferous denial arose in reply: quite a few Americans in 1913 apparently wanted to believe in the authenticity of the "Nature Man." In fact, the Joe Knowles fad was just a single and rather grotesque manifestation of popular interest in wildness.⁶ It added

2. Ibid., Oct. 10, 1913.

3. Boston *Evening Transcript*, Oct. 9, 1913.

4. Boston *Post*, Sept. 28, Oct. 5, 12, 19, 1913.

5. Boston *American*, Dec. 2, 1913.

6. After his venture in Maine, Knowles tried to repeat his stunt in California and, with a "primitive" female companion, in New York, but without success. Nor did his plan materialize for a wilderness colony where Americans could live close to nature. Ultimately, Knowles retired to an isolated shack on the coast of Washington; he died

to the evidence suggesting that by the early twentieth century appreciation of wilderness had spread from a relatively small group of Romantic and patriotic literati to become a national cult.

By the 1890s sufficient change had occurred in American life and thought to make possible a widespread reaction against the previous condemnation of wilderness. Civilization had largely subdued the continent. Labor-saving agricultural machinery and a burgeoning industry, coupled with a surge in population, turned the American focus from country to city. The census of 1890 only gave statistical confirmation to what most Americans knew first hand: the frontier was moribund, wilderness no longer dominant. From the perspective of city streets and comfortable homes, wild country inspired quite different attitudes than it had when observed from a frontiersman's clearing. No longer did the forest and Indian have to be battled in hand-to-hand combat. The average citizen could approach wilderness with the viewpoint of the vacationer rather than the conquerer. Specifically, the qualities of solitude and hardship that had intimidated many pioneers were likely to be magnetically attractive to their city-dwelling grandchildren.

Indicative of the change was the way in which many of the repugnant connotations of wilderness were transferred to the new urban environment. At the end of the nineteenth century, cities were regarded with a hostility once reserved for wild forests. In 1898 Robert A. Woods entitled a collection of exposures of Boston's slum conditions *The City Wilderness*. A few years later, Upton Sinclair's *The Jungle* employed a similar metaphor in describing the horrors of the Chicago stockyards. Too much civilization, not too little, seemed at the root of the nation's difficulties. The bugaboos of the time—"Wall Street," "trusts," "invisible government"—were phenomena of the urban, industrialized East. In regard to primitive man, American opinion was also tending to reverse the flow of two and a half centuries. Increasing numbers

October 21, 1942: Fred Lockley, "Interesting People: A Modern Cave Man," *American Magazine*, 91 (1921), 48; Boston *Post*, July 16, 1933; Stewart H. Holbrook, "The Original Nature Man," *American Mercury*, 39 (1936), 417-25, reprinted in Holbrook's *Little Annie Oakley and Other Rugged People* (New York, 1948), pp. 8-18; Richard O. Boyer, "Where Are They Now? The Nature Man," *New Yorker*, 14 (June 18, 1938), 21-25.

joined Helen Hunt Jackson in sympathizing with the Indian and identifying the disease, whiskey, and deception of civilization, not his savageness, as the crux of his problem.⁷

Along with the physical change in American life went a closely related intellectual change in temper or mood.⁸ The general optimism and hope of the antebellum years partially yielded toward the end of the century to more sober assessments, doubts, and uncertainties. Many considered the defects of their society evidence that an earlier age's bland confidence in progress was unfounded. Reasons for pessimism appeared on every hand. A flood of immigrants seemed to many to be diluting the American strain and weakening American traditions. Business values and urban living were felt to be undermining character, taste, and morality. The vast size and highly organized nature of the economy and government posed seeming obstacles to the effectiveness of the individual. Instead of the millennium, American civilization appeared to have brought confusion, corruption, and a debilitating overabundance. There existed, to be sure, a countercurrent in American thought of pride and hope, but the belief persisted that the United States, if not the entire Western world, had seen its greatest moments and was in an incipient state of decline.

7. H[elen] H. Jackson, *A Century of Dishonor: A Sketch of the United States Government's Dealings with Some of the Indian Tribes* (New York, 1881). In the succeeding decades the crimes of the white man against the Indian received extensive treatment in books and popular periodicals, while organizations like the National Indian Association and the Indian Defense Association were established to translate sentiment into action. Pearce, *Savages of America*, stops short of this period, but William T. Hagan, *American Indians* (Chicago, 1961), pp. 123 ff. is a useful discussion.

8. John Higham, "The Reorientation of American Culture in the 1890's," *The Origins of Modern Consciousness*, ed. John Weiss (Detroit, 1965) has commented perceptively on this phenomenon. I have also relied on Higham's *Strangers in the Land: Patterns of American Nativism, 1860-1925* (New York, 1963), pp. 35 ff., 158 ff.; Leo Marx, *The Machine in the Garden*; Morton and Lucia White, *The Intellectual Versus the City* (Cambridge, Mass., 1962), pp. 83 ff.; Mark Sullivan, *Our Times, 1900-1925* (6 vols. New York, 1935) 1, 137-50; Richard Hofstadter, *The Age of Reform* (New York, 1960), pp. 7-59; George E. Mowry, *The Era of Theodore Roosevelt and the Birth of Modern America, 1900-1912* (New York, 1962), pp. 85-105; Henry Steele Commager, *The American Mind: An Interpretation of American Thought and Character Since the 1880's* (New Haven, 1950), pp. 41-54, 297; Samuel P. Hays, *The Response to Industrialism, 1885-1915* (Chicago, 1957), pp. 1-47; and David Noble, "The Paradox of Progressive Thought," *American Quarterly*, 5 (1953), 201-12.

Henry F. May's *The End of American Innocence: A Study of the First Years of Our Own Time, 1912-1917* (New York, 1959) dates the breakdown in optimism and the belief in progress somewhat later.

As a result of this sense of discontent with civilization, which was no less uncomfortable because of its vagueness, *fin-de-siècle* America was ripe for the widespread appeal of the uncivilized. The cult had several facets. In the first place, there was a growing tendency to associate wilderness with America's frontier and pioneer past that was believed responsible for many unique and desirable national characteristics. Wilderness also acquired importance as a source of virility, toughness, and savagery—qualities that defined fitness in Darwinian terms. Finally, an increasing number of Americans invested wild places with aesthetic and ethical values, emphasizing the opportunity they afforded for contemplation and worship.

With a considerable sense of shock, Americans of the late nineteenth century realized that many of the forces which had shaped their national character were disappearing. Primary among these were the frontier and the frontier way of life. Long a hero of his culture, the pioneer acquired added luster at a time when the pace and complexity of American life seemed on the verge of overwhelming the independent individual. It was tempting to venerate his existence as one in which men confronted tangible obstacles and, so the myth usually ran, overcame them on the strength of ability alone. Before the 1890s it was generally assumed that because the frontiersman was good, the wilderness, as his primary adversary, was bad—the villain of the national drama. But the growing perception that the frontier era was over prompted a re-evaluation of the role of primitive conditions. Many Americans came to understand that wilderness was essential to pioneering: without wild country the concepts of frontier and pioneer were meaningless. The villain, it appeared, was as vital to the play as the hero, and, in view of the admirable qualities that contact with wilderness were thought to have produced, perhaps not so villainous as had been supposed. Toward the end of the nineteenth century, esteem for the frontiersman extended to include his environment. Pioneering, in short, came to be regarded as important not only for spearheading the advance of civilization but also for bringing Americans into contact with the primitive.

The connection between living in the wilderness and the development of desirable American traits received dramatic statement after 1893 in the historical essays of Frederick Jackson Turner. His nominal subject, of course, was the “frontier,” but he made clear

that the wildness of the country was its most basic ingredient and the essential formative influence on the national character. "The frontier," he declared, "is . . . determined by the reactions between wilderness and the edge of expanding settlement."⁹ Consequently, when Turner came to summarize the central theme of his collected essays, it was to "the transforming influence of the American wilderness" that he turned. The idea had been present in his first major address, when he spoke of the way "the wilderness masters the colonist." Gradually, to be sure, the pioneer "transforms the wilderness, but the outcome is not the old Europe. . . . The fact is, that here is a new product that is American."¹⁰ The bulk of Turner's subsequent effort was devoted to assessing the effect on American ideals and institutions of contact with a primitive environment.

Turner's most widely discussed article appeared in the *Atlantic Monthly* for September, 1896. It argued that the frontier not only made the American different from the European but better. "Out of his wilderness experience," Turner wrote, "out of the freedom of his opportunities, he fashioned a formula for social regeneration—the freedom of the individual to seek his own." Turner believed, in short, that democracy was a forest product. Living in the wilderness, "the return to primitive conditions," fostered individualism, independence, and confidence in the common man that encouraged self-government. While Turner occasionally admitted that frontier democracy had its liabilities, his attempts at impartiality only thinly masked a conviction that government by the people was far superior to Old World despotism. Indeed by virtue of being wild, the New World was a clean slate to which idealists could bring their dreams for a better life. Triumphantly, Turner concluded: "the very fact of the wilderness appealed to men as a fair, blank page on which to write a new chapter in the story of man's struggle for a higher type of society."¹¹ Associated in this way with democracy and messianic idealism, wild country acquired new value. Turner recast its role from that of an enemy which civilization had to conquer to a beneficent influence on men and institutions. His greatest service to wilderness consisted of linking it in the minds of his countrymen with sacred American virtues.

9. Turner, *The Significance of Sections in American History* (New York, 1932), p. 183.

10. Turner, *The Frontier in American History* (New York, 1920), pp. 1, 4.

11. *Ibid.*, pp. 2, 213, 311.

In 1903 Turner noted that the 1890s marked a watershed in American history: it was the first decade without a frontier. "The . . . rough conquest of the wilderness is accomplished," he pointed out, "and . . . the great supply of free lands which year after year has served to reinforce the democratic influences in the United States is exhausted." Inevitably, he wondered if American ideals "have acquired sufficient momentum to sustain themselves under conditions so radically unlike those in the days of their origin?"¹²

Turner never explicitly answered this question in his published work,¹³ but his tone suggested pessimism and contributed to a general sense of nostalgic regret over the disappearance of wilderness conditions. Articles in the nation's leading periodicals voiced concern over the "drift to the cities" and the consequent loss of pioneer qualities. Authors celebrating the "pathfinders" wondered how post-frontier Americans could comprehend their achievement.¹⁴ In 1902 Frank Norris took time from his novels to contribute "The Frontier Gone At Last" to *World's Work*. "Suddenly," it begins, "we have found that there is no longer any Frontier." The remainder of the article speculates on the meaning of this fact. Norris felt that since "there is no longer a wilderness to conquer," the "overplus" of American energy might drive the country to attempt the conquest of the world.¹⁵

The ending of the frontier prompted many Americans to seek ways of retaining the influence of wilderness in modern civilization. The Boy Scout movement was one answer. Although the English hero of the Boer War, Sir Robert S. S. Baden-Powell, was its official founder in 1907, his efforts were anticipated in this country. In 1902 the popular nature writer Ernest Thompson Seton revealed in a series of articles in the *Ladies Home Journal* his ideas for an organization of boys called Woodcraft Indians. And Seton's meeting with Baden-Powell two years later was important in arousing the Englishman's interest in scouting. Baden-Powell also had the example of organizations such as the Sons of Daniel

12. *Ibid.*, pp. 244-45, 260-61.

13. However, as a student of Turner's at Harvard during the First World War, Merle Curti remembers the concern he expressed in conversation about the future of the American character now that an urban-industrial civilization had replaced frontier conditions: interview with Merle Curti, Jan. 9, 1963.

14. G. S. Dickerson, "The Drift to the Cities," *Atlantic Monthly*, 112 (1913), 349-53; George Bird Grinnell, *Trails of the Pathfinders* (New York, 1911), pp. 11-12.

15. Norris, "The Frontier Gone At Last," *World's Work*, 3 (1902), 1728, 1729.

Boone and the Boy Pioneers which Daniel C. Beard launched in 1905. But soon after the Boy Scout concept came to America, it absorbed these forerunners, and both Seton and Beard transferred their allegiances.¹⁶

Seton set forth the methods and goals of the Boy Scouts of America in 1910 in a way that revealed the new importance Americans were according wilderness. A century ago, the Scouts' first *Handbook* begins, every American boy lived close to nature. But since then the country had undergone an "unfortunate change" marked by industrialization and the "growth of immense cities." According to Seton, the result was "degeneracy" and people who were "strained and broken by the grind of the over-busy world." As a remedy for this condition, the *Handbook* proposes that the boys of America lead the nation back to an emphasis of "Outdoor Life." This would include the realization that long and happy lives were most common among "those . . . who live nearest to the ground, that is, who live the simple life of primitive times."¹⁷ Seton then went on to give instruction in woodlore and campcraft, in the hope that boys would spend at least a month of every year away from civilization, keeping in contact with frontier skills and values.

The Boy Scouts' striking success (it quickly became the largest youth organization in the country) is a significant commentary on American thinking in the early twentieth century. In thirty years the *Handbook* sold an alleged seven million copies in the United States, second only to the Bible.¹⁸ The Scouting movement caught the public eye by offering a solution to the disturbing phenomenon of a civilization that seemed to be tearing itself away from the frontier roots that many felt to be the source of its greatness. It implemented the boast of Joe Knowles that "simply because we are

16. William Hillcourt, *Baden-Powell: The Two Lives of a Hero* (New York, 1964), pp. 247 ff.; Howard Fast, *Lord Baden-Powell of the Boy Scouts* (New York, 1941), pp. 171 ff.; Seton, *Trail of an Artist-Naturalist: The Autobiography of Ernest Thompson Seton* (New York, 1940), pp. 374-85; Beard, *Hardly a Man is Now Alive: The Autobiography of Dan Beard* (New York, 1939), pp. 351-61; Harold P. Levy, *Building a Popular Movement: A Case Study of the Public Relations of the Boy Scouts of America* (New York, 1944).

17. Seton, *Boy Scouts of America: A Handbook of Woodcraft, Scouting, and Life-craft* (New York, 1910), pp. xi, xii, 1, 2.

18. Fast, *Baden-Powell*, p. 192; Boy Scouts of America, *Handbook for Boys* (New York, 1938), p. 6. For a history of the movement see William D. Murray, *The History of the Boy Scouts of America* (New York, 1937).

a civilized people does not mean that the days of wilderness colonization are over."¹⁹

Another response to the vanishing frontier was the rise of popular interest in preserving portions of the American wilderness. While wild country still existed to the West, the preservation concept had found favor with only a few farsighted individuals. Yellowstone National Park (1872) and the Adirondack Forest Preserve (1885) were not established to protect wilderness. After 1890, however, the disappearance of the frontier environment became more obvious. The resulting sense of nostalgia prompted, for one thing, belated recognition of the wilderness values of the first national and state reservations in Wyoming and northern New York (Chapter 7). The 1890s were also the years in which John Muir found numerous countrymen ready to join the preservationist wing of the conservation movement. Americans of this generation also responded to the ideas of another important wilderness publicizer: Theodore Roosevelt.

On February 10, 1894, Roosevelt wrote to Frederick Jackson Turner thanking him for a copy of his 1893 address on the significance of the American frontier. "I think you have struck some first class ideas," Roosevelt asserted, "and have put into definite shape a good deal of thought which has been floating around rather loosely."²⁰ Indeed, Roosevelt himself anticipated many of Turner's ideas, and even his rhetoric, in his 1889 *The Winning of the West*. "Under the hard conditions of life in the wilderness," Roosevelt wrote, those who migrated to the New World "lost all remembrance of Europe" and became new men "in dress, in customs, and in mode of life."²¹ He too realized that by the 1890s "the frontier had come to an end; it had vanished."²² This alarmed Roosevelt chiefly because of its anticipated effect on national virility and greatness.

19. Joseph Knowles, *Alone in the Wilderness* (Boston, 1913), p. 286. As might be expected, Knowles enthusiastically supported Scouting: *Alone*, pp. 239-53.

20. *Letters of Theodore Roosevelt*, ed. Elting Morison (8 vols. Cambridge, Mass., 1951-54) 1, 363.

21. Roosevelt, *The Winning of the West*, *The Works of Theodore Roosevelt*, Memorial edition (23 vols. New York, 1924-26) 10, 101-102. For an indication of the extent of Turner's debt to Roosevelt see Wilbur R. Jacobs, *Frederick Jackson Turner's Legacy* (San Marino, Cal., 1965), p. 153. The present quotation (1889) is too similar in both conception and wording to Turner's "transformation" passage (1893) in *Frontier*, p. 4, to be purely coincidental.

22. Roosevelt, *The Wilderness Hunter*, *Works*, 2, 13.

The study of American history and personal experience combined to convince Roosevelt that living in wilderness promoted "that vigorous manliness for the lack of which in a nation, as in an individual, the possession of no other qualities can possibly atone." Conversely, he felt, the modern American was in real danger of becoming an "overcivilized man, who has lost the great fighting, masterful virtues." To counter this trend toward "flabbiness" and "slothful ease" Roosevelt in 1899 called upon his countrymen to lead a "life of strenuous endeavor." This included keeping in contact with wilderness: pioneering was an important antidote to dull mediocrity. "As our civilization grows older and more complex," Roosevelt explained, "we need a greater and not a less development of the fundamental frontier virtues."²³

Roosevelt led the way personally. Immediately after graduating from Harvard, he spent considerable time in the 1880s on his ranch in the Dakota Territories, exulting in the frontiersman's life. He even had himself photographed posing proudly in a buckskin suit.²⁴ Later, when official duties demanded attention, he still found time for hunting and camping trips in wild country. Once, in a preface to a collection of hunting stories, Roosevelt attempted to articulate his feelings. "There are no words," he began, "that can tell of the hidden spirit of the wilderness, that can reveal its mystery, its melancholy, and its charm. There is delight in the hardy life of the open, in long rides rifle in hand, in the thrill of the fight with dangerous game." In addition he confessed a strong aesthetic attraction to "the silent places . . . the wide waste places of the earth, unworn of man, and changed only by the slow change of the ages through time everlasting."²⁵

Understandably, Roosevelt was delighted that his country had taken the lead in establishing wilderness preserves and urged "every believer in manliness . . . every lover of nature, every man who appreciates the majesty and beauty of the wilderness and of wild life" to give them full support. In 1903, as President, he toured Yellowstone and Yosemite National Parks and came away delighted that these "bits of the old wilderness scenery and the old

23. Ibid., xxxi; Roosevelt, "The Strenuous Life" in *Works*, 15, 267, 271, 281; Roosevelt, "The Pioneer Spirit and American Problems" in *Works*, 18, 23.

24. Herman Hagedorn, *Roosevelt in the Bad Lands* (Boston, 1921). Photographs appear as a frontispiece and on p. 236.

25. Roosevelt, *African Game Trails*, *Works*, 5, xxvii.

wilderness life are to be kept unspoiled for the benefit of our children's children." In Roosevelt's opinion, America needed these remnants of the pioneer environment, because "no nation facing the unhealthy softening and relaxation of fibre that tends to accompany civilization can afford to neglect anything that will develop hardihood, resolution, and the scorn of discomfort and danger."²⁶ The wilderness preserves would serve this purpose by providing a perpetual frontier and keeping Americans in contact with primitive conditions. The rapid growth of the preservation movement, which reached a climax after 1910 in the Hetch Hetchy controversy (Chapter 10), suggests that a sizeable number of Americans joined with their President in detecting a national malaise and shared his faith in a wilderness cure.

"The friendly and flowing savage, who is he? Is he waiting for civilization, or past it and mastering it?" So asked Walt Whitman in a poem given final form in 1881. His question was not idle for the growing portion of his generation that entertained doubts about the happiness and vigor of modern man. Evidence of American decadence spurred primitivism. Wilderness and savages seemed to have advantages over civilized nature and man. Whitman himself sought wildness in 1876 when, broken in health and depressed from the experience of civil war, he retreated to Timber Creek, New Jersey. Along its "primitive windings" he found relief from "the whole cast-iron civilized life" and the chance to return to "the naked source-life of us all—to the breast of the great silent savage all-acceptive Mother."²⁷ Gradually Whitman recovered his physical strength and creative powers. Combined with his constant literary apotheosis of the unrepressed and wild, the Timber Creek interlude made Whitman's initial question seem rhetorical.

Whitman was a precursor of the American celebration of savagery. In full stride by the second decade of the twentieth century, it contributed to the rising popularity of wilderness. While related to the attraction of the frontier and pioneer, this aspect of the cult had more to do with racism, Darwinism, and a tradition of idealiz-

26. Roosevelt, "Wilderness Reserves: The Yellowstone Park" in *Works*, 3, 267, 288, 311–12.

27. Whitman, "Song of Myself" in *Leaves of Grass* (Garden City, N.Y., 1917), p. 88; Whitman, *Specimen Days* (Philadelphia, 1882–83), pp. 83–84. Secondary commentary appears in Fussell, *Frontier*, pp. 397–441.

ing the noble savage in his wilderness setting that ran back several thousand years (see Chapter 3). Ancient cultures, when inclined to self-criticism, began the practice of regarding those less civilized than themselves as superior. The spectacle of barbaric hordes sweeping down on a moribund and effete Roman Empire permanently impressed Western thought with the idea that virile manliness and wildness were closely linked. Early American experimenters with primitivistic themes, notably Thoreau, Melville, and Whitman, provided the immediate literary background for the growth of interest in savagery.²⁸ But it owed much more to a general feeling that the American male was suffering from over-civilization.

Theodore Roosevelt again took the lead in applauding savage virtues. Without advocating a return to cave-dwelling on a permanent basis, he still hoped that the opportunity for modern Americans to experience wilderness and lead for a time the savage way of life would not be totally eliminated. In 1888, with a view to implementing his ideas, Roosevelt organized the Boone and Crockett Club. Its stated purpose was the encouragement of big-game hunting, but the character of the hunter was the real object of concern. To qualify for membership it was necessary to have collected three trophy heads, and along with Roosevelt (who had eight) the founding nucleus included Elihu Root, Madison Grant, and Henry Cabot Lodge.²⁹ Of course Americans had always shot game, but this group of wealthy hunters coupled their sport with an unprecedented primitivistic philosophy. As Roosevelt and co-author George Bird Grinnell expressed it in a Boone and Crockett publication of 1893, "hunting big game in the wilderness is . . . a sport for a vigorous and masterful people." To succeed in a primitive environment, they continued, the hunter "must be sound of body and firm of mind, and must possess energy, resolution, manliness, self-reliance, and a capacity for self-help." The statement ended with the thought that these were characteristics "without which

28. See Chapter 5 for Thoreau and, for Melville, Fussell, pp. 232 ff. along with James Baird, *Ishmael* (Baltimore, 1956) and Charles Roberts Anderson, *Melville in the South Seas* (New York, 1939).

29. Paul Russell Cutright, *Theodore Roosevelt: The Naturalist* (New York, 1956), pp. 68–79; James B. Trefethen, *Crusade for Wildlife: Highlights in Conservation Progress* (New York, 1961), pp. 24 ff.; George Bird Grinnell, ed., *Brief History of the Boone and Crockett Club* (New York, 1910).

no race can do its life work well; and . . . the very qualities which it is the purpose of this Club . . . to develop and foster.”³⁰

Testimony from individual sportsmen supported this point of view. William Kent, a California congressman and conservationist (see Chapter 10), regretted that “since the days of the cave men our race has gone . . . degenerate.” As a corrective measure, he rejoiced in the savagery of hunting. After a kill, Kent declared, “you are a barbarian, and you’re glad of it. It’s good to be a barbarian . . . and you know that if you are a barbarian, you are at any rate a man.” In conclusion Kent called on his contemporaries to “go out into the wilderness and learn the endurance of nature which endures.”³¹ Hunting, once strictly a utilitarian activity, had been given a new rationale.

The surge of interest among Americans in primitive environments for purposes of recreation indicated that the ideology of the Boone and Crockett Club and William Kent was not esoteric. Wilderness camping and mountain climbing became an important part of the widespread “outdoor movement.”³² These pursuits had a special appeal to city people, who found in them temporary relief from artificiality and confinement. As one enthusiast put it in 1904, “whenever the light of civilization falls upon you with a blighting power . . . go to the wilderness.” There, he continued, it was possible “to return to the primitive, the elemental” and escape “the perils of envious cities.” Temporarily one partook of “the ruggedness of the mountains, the sturdiness of the oaks, the relentless savagery of the wind.” The end result was to “give you good red blood; [to] turn you from a weakling into a man.”³³ A tribute to Joe Knowles at a banquet in his honor took up the same theme: “there is too much refinement. It leads to degeneration. My friend Knowles has taught us how to live on nothing. It is better than living on too much. We should all get down to nature.”³⁴

30. Grinnell, “The Boone and Crockett Club” in *American Big Game Hunting: The Book of the Boone and Crockett Club*, ed. Roosevelt and Grinnell (Edinburgh, 1893), pp. 14–15.

31. William Kent, “Out Doors,” Kent Family Papers, Historical Manuscripts Room, Yale University Library, New Haven, Conn., Box 100.

32. Foster Rhea Dulles, *America Learns to Play: A History of Popular Recreation* (New York, 1940), pp. 202 ff.

33. George S. Evans, “The Wilderness,” *Overland Monthly*, 43 (1904), 33.

34. James B. Connolly as quoted in the *Boston Post*, Oct. 12, 1913.

Americans with similar sentiments formed the core of the numerous outdoor clubs that appeared in the late nineteenth century. The Appalachian Mountain Club (1876) in the East, and the Sierra Club (1892) in the West organized wilderness enthusiasts and became stalwarts in the campaign for its preservation. The Mazamas of Portland, Oregon began in 1894 with a meeting of 155 hardy climbers on top of Mount Hood. Three years later the Campfire Club of America was founded.³⁵ For the members of these and other groups, part of the value of a wilderness trip was masochistic in that it provided a chance to play the savage, accept punishment, struggle, and, hopefully, triumph over the forces of raw nature. "The man in the woods," declared Stewart Edward White in 1903, "matches himself against the forces of nature." Confronting wilderness "is a test, a measuring of strength, a proving of his essential pluck and resourcefulness and manhood, an assurance of man's highest potency, the ability to endure and to take care of himself."³⁶ Meeting such a challenge assuaged fears that Americans were not what they used to be.

Carried to the extent of Joe Knowles' alleged exploit, the successful struggle against the primitive had a tonic effect on national pride and confidence. Knowles himself was aware of this implication and declared that his purpose in spending two months in the wilderness without equipment was "to demonstrate the self-sustaining power of modern man; to prove that man, though handicapped with the habits of civilization, is the physical equal of his early ancestors, and has not altogether lost . . . [their] resourcefulness."³⁷ Reacting to the reported success of the experiment, many felt Knowles' greatest significance was to put the human element back into the spotlight; to show that even without machines man still deserved his place atop the Darwinian tree of life. As one

35. See Chapter 8, and Allen H. Bent, "The Mountaineering Clubs of America," *Appalachia*, 14 (1916), 5-18. For the Appalachian Mountain Club, in particular, the records at the Clubs' Headquarters, Boston, are most useful.

It is interesting that the German *Wandervogel*, under the leadership of Karl Fischer and Hermann Hoffmann, took to Europe's woodlands and mountains as a protest against the emptiness of civilization at precisely the same time that the American wilderness cult flourished. See Gerhard Masur, *Prophets of Yesterday: Studies in European Culture, 1890-1914* (New York, 1961), pp. 356-68, and Walter Z. Laqueur, *Young Germany: A History of the German Youth Movement* (London, 1962), pp. 3-38.

36. White, *The Forest* (New York, 1903), p. 5.

37. *Boston Post*, Aug. 17, 1913.

journal commented editorially, what Knowles accomplished in Maine “is a good deal more comforting to our proper human pride than the erection of a Woolworth building.”³⁸

Realizing the growing attractiveness of the wild for recreation, advertisers took account in their publicity of the thirst for the primitive. In 1911, for example, the Bangor and Aroostook Railroad Company, anxious to have vacationers ride its cars into Maine, began issuing a yearly publication, *In the Maine Woods*. A typical passage began with the observation that “there’s a good deal of the primitive in most of us” and concluded that consequently “we feel the magic beckoning of old Mother Nature to rise up from the thralldom of business . . . and to betake ourselves to the woods.” Maine, of course, was the suggested destination as a region “still rich in primeval charms.”³⁹ For those who could not travel this far, landscape architects such as Frederick Law Olmsted and Charles Eliot proposed that in addition to city parks patches of “wild forest” be preserved close to metropolitan areas.⁴⁰ In them, Eliot contended in 1891, men could find relief from the “poisonous struggling . . . of city life” and the resulting feeling of exhaustion and depression.⁴¹ Olmsted felt the current surge of interest in natural landscapes was the result of many Americans’ perceiving that “we grow more and more artificial day by day.” A “self-preserving instinct of civilization,” he thought, led it to parks and preserves as a means of resisting “‘vital exhaustion,’ ” “‘nervous irritation,’ ” and “‘constitutional depression.’ ”⁴²

The reading as well as the recreational tastes of many Americans of the early twentieth century were inclined toward the wild and savage. “Natural history” became a major literary genre. John Burroughs was only the best known of several score writers who kept

38. Anonymous, “Naked Man,” *Hearst’s Magazine*, 24 (1913), 954.

39. Bangor and Aroostook Railroad Company, *In the Maine Woods* (Bangor, 1911), p. 7.

40. Charles Eliot to Charles Francis Adams, Oct. 6, 1892, Charles Eliot Manuscript Letters, 1892–97, Eliot Papers, Library of the Graduate School of Design, Harvard University.

41. Eliot, “The Need of Parks,” *Souvenir of the Banquet of the Advance Club*, Publications of the Advance Club, 6 (Providence, R.I., 1891), p. 63.

42. Olmsted, *A Consideration of the Justifying Value of a Public Park* (Boston, 1881), p. 19. For Olmsted’s earlier arguments in favor of the protection of Yosemite Valley see Chapter 6. John William Ward’s “The Politics of Design,” *Massachusetts Review*, 6 (1965), 660–88, analyzes the motives of Olmsted as well as earlier designers of the American landscape.

the public's appetite satiated with a deluge of articles and books ranging from robins to grizzlies.⁴³ Among works of fiction, one of the best sellers of the early twentieth century was Jack London's *The Call of the Wild*. Published in 1903, it told the story of a huge dog, Buck, who was stolen from his master's ranch in California and sold into the Klondike to haul sleds. Exposed to primitive conditions, Buck gradually threw off his domesticated habits and became "the dominant primordial beast." At the close of the novel he had reverted all the way to the wolf, and London pictured him "running at the head of the pack through the pale moonlight or glimmering borealis, leaping gigantic above his fellows, his great throat a-bellow as he sings a song of the younger world." London left no doubt that it was also the song of a more vital, stronger and generally superior world, and his readers had little difficulty seeing the moral for their own lives in Buck's reversion to the primitive. Significantly, London's *White Fang* (1906), in which a wolf became a family dog, never enjoyed the popularity of *The Call of the Wild*.

Savagery, of course, received its most triumphant literary expression at this time in Edgar Rice Burroughs' stories about an English infant reared in the jungle by apes. Burroughs began experimenting with the theme in 1912, and two years later published one of America's most widely read books, *Tarzan of the Apes*. Like Buck, Tarzan benefitted from his contact with the wilderness to the extent of becoming a superman.⁴⁴

The third major component of the wilderness cult lacked the hairy-chestedness of the previous ideas and instead accorded wild country value as a source of beauty and spiritual truth. This outlook, of course, depended on an intellectual revolution occurring over the previous several centuries, and echoed the familiar Romantic rhetoric (see Chapter 3). But several circumstances of late-

43. Hans Huth, *Nature and the American: Three Centuries of Changing Attitudes* (Berkeley, Cal., 1957), p. 87 ff.; Philip Marshall Hicks, *The Development of the Natural History Essay in American Literature* (Philadelphia, 1924), pp. 100-158; Norman Foerster, *Nature in American Literature* (New York, 1923), pp. 264-305; Francis C. Halsey, "The Rise of the Nature Writers," *American Monthly Review of Reviews*, 26 (1902), 567-71; Anonymous, "Back to Nature," *Outlook*, 74 (1903), 305-07.

44. London, *The Call of the Wild* (New York, 1903), pp. 99, 231. The popularity of London and Burroughs is discussed in Alice Payne Hackett, *60 Years of Best Sellers, 1895-1955* (New York, 1956) and Frank Luther Mott, *Golden Multitudes: The Story of Best Sellers in the United States* (New York, 1947).

nineteenth century America combined to give it new urgency and unprecedented public appeal. As the antipode of civilization, of cities, and of machines, wilderness could be associated with the virtues these entities lacked. In the primitive, specifically, many Americans detected the qualities of innocence, purity, cleanliness, and morality which seemed on the verge of succumbing to utilitarianism and the surge of progress. And at a time when the force of religion seemed vitiated by the new scientism on the one hand and social conflict on the other,⁴⁵ wilderness acquired special significance as a resuscitator of faith. Joe Knowles, for one, knew the value of his trip was partly spiritual. "My God is in the wilderness," he wrote, "the great open book of nature is my religion. My church is the church of the forest."⁴⁶

Wild scenery enthralled Americans of this mind. They provided the market for elaborate albums such as James W. Buel's 1893 prodigy, *America's Wonderlands: Pictorial and Descriptive History of Our Country's Scenic Marvels as Delineated by Pen and Camera*, and for their vacations thronged the White and Adirondack Mountains, and later the Rockies and Sierra.⁴⁷ These people also looked favorably on wilderness preservation: protection of wild country seemed part of the defense of the finer things of life. Frederick Law Olmsted expressed the idea when he defended "the contemplation of beauty in natural scenery" for its effect in countering "excessive materialism, . . . loss of faith and lowness of spirit."⁴⁸ In the United States Senate, George G. Vest of Missouri made a similar analysis. Speaking in defense of Yellowstone National Park, he declared that "the great curse of this age and of the American people is its materialistic tendency. Money, money, l'argent, l'argent is the cry everywhere, until our people are held up . . . to the world as noted for nothing except the acquisition of money at the expense of all esthetic taste and of all love of nature."⁴⁹ In 1890, Olmsted generalized that any time a wilderness preserve was endangered the public

45. Arthur Schlesinger, "A Critical Period in American Religion, 1875-1900," *Proceedings of the Massachusetts Historical Society*, 64 (1932), 523-47.

46. Knowles, *Alone*, pp. 224-25.

47. Huth, *Nature*, pp. 54-86, 105-47. The White Mountain Collection, Baker Library, Dartmouth College, Hanover, N.H. and the Frederick W. Kilborne White Mountain Collection, Appalachian Mountain Club, Boston, reveal the varied forms of popular enthusiasm for wilderness vacationing.

48. Olmsted, *Consideration*, pp. 19-20.

49. *Congressional Record*, 47th Cong., 2d Sess., 14 (March 1, 1883), p. 3488.

should respond as they would "to any crisis threatening a national treasure of art."⁵⁰

It was precisely this sentiment that John Muir and Robert Underwood Johnson endeavored to arouse in the following decades. Muir continually lamented "these mad, God-forgetting progressive days,"⁵¹ and his rhetoric, steeped in Transcendentalism, created a style for appreciating wilderness. Echoing their president, Sierra Club members like Marion Randall returned from mountain trips with the feeling that "for a little while you have dwealt close to the heart of things . . . [and] drawn near Him." She declared herself ready at once "to turn to the hills again, whence comes, not only your help, but your strength, your inspiration, and some of the brightest hours you have ever lived." In 1894, the *Sierra Club Bulletin* carried a reproof of anyone "blessed" with a view of wilderness "yet who feels no exaltation of soul, no supreme delight in the conscious exercise or stirring of that something within us we call the aesthetic." Muir himself went still further in labeling as "selfish seekers of immediate Mammon" those who could bring only utilitarian criteria to wild places.⁵²

As a self-styled upholder of his country's "standards"⁵³ and one of the pillars of its "genteel tradition,"⁵⁴ Robert Underwood Johnson represented the social type that furnished a large proportion of wilderness enthusiasts. The bookish, dapper Johnson had little desire for actual contact with the primitive and, by his own admission, was an inept outdoorsman. His interest, rather, lay in the *idea* of wilderness as something pure, beautiful, and delicate, embattled against what he conceived to be ruthless exploitation. Indeed, he referred to his many efforts before Congress on behalf of preserva-

50. Olmsted, "Governmental Preservation of Natural Scenery," *Sierra Club Bulletin*, 29 (1944), 62.

51. Muir to George Plimpton, Dec. 9, 1913, Johnson Papers, Berkeley, Box 7.

52. Randall, "Some Aspects of a Sierra Club Outing," *Sierra Club Bulletin*, 5 (1905), 227-28; P. B. Van Trump, "Mt. Tahoma," *Sierra Club Bulletin*, 1 (1894), 115; Muir to Robert Underwood Johnson, March 14, 1894, Johnson Papers, Berkeley, Box 7.

53. U.S. Congress, Senate, Committee on the Public Lands, Hearings, *Hetch Hetchy Reservoir Site*, 63rd Cong., 1st Sess. (Sept. 24, 1913), p. 46.

54. George Santayana, *The Genteel Tradition in American Philosophy* (Berkeley, Cal., 1911); John Tomsich, "The Genteel Tradition in America, 1850-1910" (unpublished Ph.D. dissertation, University of Wisconsin, 1963); Richard Cary, *The Genteel Circle: Bayard Taylor and his New York Friends*, Cornell Studies in American History, Literature, and Folklore, 5 (Ithaca, N.Y., 1952), pp. 1-21.

tion as “‘spiritual lobbying.’”⁵⁵ Johnson hoped they might contribute to advancing Americans to the point where they could “throw off the two shackles that retard our progress as an artistic nation—philistinism and commercialism—and advance with freedom toward the Love of Beauty as a Principle.”⁵⁶ Appreciating the value of wilderness was a step in the right direction, and it was especially significant to Johnson that this recognition had spread by the early twentieth century far beyond a coterie of Romantic writers. The successes John Muir and Johnson himself enjoyed with the wilderness theme in prominent magazines such as *Century*, *Harper's*, and *Atlantic* testified to the nation's receptivity. So, in part, did the growth of the preservation movement: lovers of wild scenery became a major force within conservation.⁵⁷ Even at the utilitarian-minded Governors' Conference on Conservation in 1908, the Romantic viewpoint had its exponents. J. Horace McFarland, president of the American Civic Association, spoke of God's refuge “in the very bosom of nature, to which we may flee from the noise and strain of the market-place for that renewing of spirit and strength which can not be had elsewhere.” The representative of the American Scenic and Historic Preservation Society, George F. Kunz, added that it was not “empty sentimentalism” which led many in his generation to covet the aesthetic and spiritual qualities of wilderness, but rather the realization that happiness and “the highest development of our people” depended on them.⁵⁸ The widespread public acceptance of ideas such as these made it possible for Johnson, Muir, and other preservationists to arouse a national protest in 1913 against the construction of a dam in Yosemite National Park's wild Hetch Hetchy Valley (Chapter 10).

A comparison of the reputations of John Muir and Henry David Thoreau among their contemporaries dramatizes the appearance of

55. Johnson, *Remembered Yesterdays*, pp. 239 ff. The Robert Underwood Johnson Papers at the New York Public Library substantiate his wideranging interest in art, culture, creativity, and refinement.

56. Johnson, “John Muir as I Knew Him,” (typescript c. 1915) John Muir Papers, American Academy of Arts and Letters, New York.

57. Hays, *Conservation*, pp. 141 ff.; Charles D. Smith, “The Movement for Eastern National Forests, 1890–1911” (unpublished Ph.D. dissertation, Harvard University, 1956), esp. pp. 1–17 and 357 ff.

58. *Proceedings of a Conference of Governors in the White House . . . May 13–15, 1908*, ed. Newton C. Blanchard et al., U.S. House of Representatives Doc. 1425, 60th Cong., 2d Sess., pp. 140, 156, 419.

a wilderness cult. Both men made wilderness their dominant concern, yet the extent to which they were successful and influential figures in their lifetimes differed markedly. In 1853 Thoreau was obliged to find storage space for the seven hundred unsold volumes of a thousand-copy printing of his first book, *A Week on the Concord and Merrimack Rivers*.⁵⁹ Just over forty years later, Muir happily wrote Johnson that bookstores could not supply the demand for his initial book-length work, *The Mountains of California*.⁶⁰ The authors' comments were symbolic. While he lived, Thoreau's supporters consisted of a handful of personal friends. His writings went unsold and his lectures were sparsely attended. The general public regarded the Walden Pond episode as incomprehensible at best.⁶¹ Muir, on the contrary, was highly successful and nationally acclaimed in spite of the fact that most of his thoughts were simply restatements of the Transcendentalists' case for wilderness. The context rather than the content of the respective philosophies determined their popularity. Like Joe Knowles, it was Muir's good fortune to live at a time when he could reap the honors that belatedly came to Thoreau's ideas.

The American cult of the wilderness that lifted Muir, and for that matter, Thoreau, into prominence was not, to be sure, overwhelming, nor was the popularity of primitivism the only manifestation of discontent and frustration at the end of the nineteenth century. In a complex age, it was but a single current of thought. Even in the minds of those who championed wilderness, pride in the accomplishments of American civilization and a belief in the virtues of further development of natural resources persisted. Yet by the twentieth century's second decade something of a divide had been passed. Sufficient misgivings about the effects of civilization had arisen to encourage a favorable opinion of wilderness that contrasted sharply with earlier American attitudes.

59. Torrey and Allen, eds, *Journal*, 5, 459.

60. Muir to Johnson, Jan. 10, 1895, Johnson Papers, Berkeley, Box 7.

61. On Thoreau's unpopularity in his own time see Carl Bode, *The Anatomy of American Popular Culture* (Berkeley, 1959), p. x, and Walter Harding, "Thoreau on the Lecture Platform," *New England Quarterly*, 24 (1951), 365-67.